

Marketing Essentials

Marketing yourself as a home performance contractor will require creating a new marketing plan. While doing nothing clearly won't get those jobs rolling in, there is no one right way to reach homeowners who need your services. Rather than trying to devise a plan from scratch, try borrowing some tips from the experts. Five leaders in the home performance field—Greg Thomas, Dick Kornbluth, Larry Taylor, Darin Hughes, and Carl Seville—reveal how they get their phones to ring.



G. HODGES

Greg Thomas, Performance Systems Contracting: *Marketing is a key system to build and maintain.*

The key to marketing home performance is remembering that trying to educate one customer at a time about the unique services you provide as a home performance contractor is too expensive and time consuming. You need to get other people to educate customers for you, or invest in educating customers through the media, or both. Referrals are some of the best customers, since they have been educated about your company and your services by someone they trust. Work hard to generate referrals by taking good care of your customers. You can also get leverage in educating customers through delivering presentations. We once did a presentation that only one person attended. But he was a home inspector. And we got a steady stream of referrals from that inspector for years after. We have recently invested in radio and TV ads. A sample of our radio ad can be

found at our contracting company Web site, www.pscontracting.com.



DALE HOFMEIER

Dick Kornbluth, EnTherm, Incorporated: *It is difficult to market home performance, because the concepts do not lend themselves easily to 30- or 60-second sound bites.*

But difficult doesn't mean impossible; it just means thinking about marketing a little more creatively. If you offer multiple services, market all of those services in the same venues that you have always marketed your individual services, but tweak your message. For example, if you have traditionally advertised in a local newspaper's special fall home issue, then continue to do so; just make sure to mention specific benefits that you can provide that homeowners need. If there are specific climate-related problems in your area, such as ice dams in the winter or cooling comfort problems in the summer, market your ability to provide solutions to those problems.

To get more effect from your marketing efforts, market home performance concepts in front of a group of people. Create these opportunities by offering yourself as a speaker to real estate companies that do in-house continuing education credits or CEUs, or to service organizations like Lions or Rotary clubs. Home and trade shows are effective venues because they give you the ability to expand your message. The important thing is to get in the house, and that can only happen once people know about the services you offer.



AIRRITE

Larry Taylor, AirRite Air Conditioning Company, Incorporated: *You must refocus your marketing efforts when you move into home performance contracting.*

Customer referral programs are critical marketing tools and an excellent place to start; consider developing a list of customers who are willing to give you a video or audio referral. You must create new professional presentations that reassure customers that the health, safety, and comfort decisions they are making really will benefit their families.

Another excellent marketing effort has been our involvement in the Cowtown Executives Networking group. There we have the opportunity to tell our story to 80 or so other business sales people who, when talking to their customers, are able to refer business to us. There are many of these groups available, and we belong to several others as well.

Additionally we have installed a device called Copy Rider on the back of our service trucks that have six rolling scrolls in them. They rotate every minute while driving and tell our story on the highway. When we come to a stop light they go into a 15-second rotation while stopped. This is increasing our ability to tell our story, and the feedback we are receiving continues to grow each month. We replace these every quarter with a new set to tell a new story.



GREENHOMES AMERICA, LLC

**Darin Hughes,
GreenHomes America,
LLC:** *First, and
foremost, new
home performance
contracting (HPC)
business owners can
market to their
existing client base.*

Hopefully, you've established a good relationship with them already, and chances are they haven't heard of

HPC. These customers are what we call low-hanging fruit. The health, comfort, and safety of their family have always been important to them; now energy efficiency is top of mind with every homeowner as well. These messages resonate powerfully with potential HPC customers.

Word of mouth is also very powerful in this market. Once you have a satisfied customer in the neighborhood, you'll probably be getting more calls from that customer's friends and neighbors. Of course, all the traditional marketing vehicles work well also. Basically, you just have to get your name and the HPC value proposition out to the public, and your phones will start ringing off the hook.



CARL SEVILLE

**Carl Seville,
Sustainability
Consultant:** *Remodelers should
consider seasonal
marketing campaigns
that mimic HVAC
contractors' methods.*

In the winter, stress staying warm and saving energy; in the summer, focus on keeping cool and lowering electric bills.

Finally, find out if any utilities, governmental agencies, professional organizations, or nonprofits may be offering incentives or partnerships to builders and remodelers in your market. The new federal tax bill has incorporated tax credits for various home improvements. However it remains to be seen whether these incentives will stimulate the market enough to make a difference. Incentives, along with preferential financing, will stimulate interest in energy efficiency and likely increase customer inquiries on the subject. Whether or not any specific project is able to take advantage of available incentives, simply having more homeowners inquire about their options means that renovators may have more selling opportunities.

